

Make a sound feel remembered

A practical landscape guide for the AU and VST3 audio effect. Six recipes start on page 6.

PATINA

Darker colour. Gentle drift. Digital wear. Space.

PATINA processes audio you already have: piano, synths, drums, voice or environmental recordings. Insert it after your instrument or on an audio track. It does not make notes or import samples.

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New in 0.5.2: use the arrows beside the preset menu to browse. They replace the selected bank, so SAVE first to keep your sound.

Your first minute

1. Play a piano or synth loop through PATINA.
2. Select bank A and choose **Subtle tape**.
3. Keep FX POWER orange. If the button says RESUME FX, click it to release Restore.
4. Leave Evolve off. Raise Wear to taste and use Mix to blend the treatment.
5. Copy to B, try a stronger setting, then compare A and B.

01 / Shape the ageing

Hover over controls for help. Drag a dial, double-click it to reset, or click its value box to type.

Control	What it does	Useful starting point
Wear	Sets the amount of age directly when Evolve is off; sets the target when Evolve is on.	20-45% for gentle colour.
Age Time	5-180 seconds to reach the Wear target with Evolve enabled.	45-90 s for a gradual transition.
Instability	Pitch drift, flutter and a little signal-following dust.	0-15% for tuned keys; increase for wobble.
Mix	Blends the ageing treatment; also scales the added lo-fi, delay and reverb.	40-65%; use less to retain attack.
Output	Gain from -24 to +12 dB. Added effects can increase the final peaks.	Start at 0 dB; lower if peaks turn red.
Character	Fresh, Remembered and Almost forgotten become progressively more faded.	Remembered for softly aged instruments.

The status message beside the display explains Bypass, Restore, a zero main Mix or inactive lo-fi settings. It follows the current page and selected bank.

Evolve: age grows while the host plays or audible live input arrives. **Restore:** latches the effect fresh and resets age; click RESUME FX to release it. **Repeatable:** resets age, drift and tails when playback starts or seeks, when host timing is available.

The central percentage is the actual smoothed wear. The moving graph shows recent output peaks, not a frequency spectrum. Age Time does not set a delay or reverb length.

02 / Add space

Delay and reverb sit after the ageing and lo-fi stages. Orange LEDs mean enabled; Amount still sets the audible contribution.

Delay: rhythm or a soft echo

Time: 30-1200 ms with TEMPO SYNC off. Changing time glides the echo pitch.

Feedback: 0-75%. More feedback creates longer repeating trails.

Amount: added echo level. Start at 10-25%.

TEMPO SYNC: disables the millisecond dial. Choose the musical division instead. Both channels follow that interval.

Reverb: distance and atmosphere

Size: moves from compact rooms towards spacious tails.

Amount: adds diffuse ambience. Start at 10-20% for keys or drums, 25-35% for pads.

Click the Reverb LED to compare without changing its settings. The effect keeps running in the background, so re-enabling it may reveal a current tail.

Reduce Amount before Size when a part feels too distant.

Reading divisions: $1/4$ = a quarter note; $1/8 D$ = dotted eighth; $1/4 T$ = quarter-note triplet. At 120 BPM these are 500 ms, 375 ms and about 333 ms. The host tempo display identifies HOST or the 120 BPM FALLBACK.

For clean comparisons, leave some space between notes. Turning up Delay and Reverb together can raise peaks; use Output to leave headroom. Repeatable clears tails on playback restarts or detected seeks.

03 / Add lo-fi texture

Click LO-FI beside the centre display. It replaces the main knob row; MAIN CONTROLS brings that row back.

Control	How to use it
Crush Mix	Blends in the crushed signal. At 0%, Bit Depth and Rate Reduction have no audible contribution. Try 15-30% first.
Bit Depth	4-16 bits. Lower values make quantisation rougher and more obvious, especially in quiet details. Start at 10-12 bits.
Rate Reduction	1-24x. Larger values hold samples longer and add coarse, aliasing textures. 1x leaves the sample rate unreduced. Try 2-4x.
Hiss	Noise follows the input level and fades after notes. It works independently of Crush Mix. Start at 5-15%.
Lo-fi LED	Enables or disables the whole section while retaining its settings. FX POWER, Restore and the main Mix also affect what you hear.

A musical balance

For a soft worn edge, keep Bit Depth around 10-12, use moderate Rate Reduction and blend with Crush Mix. If chords lose definition, reduce Rate Reduction first. If quiet decays become gritty, increase Bit Depth.

A useful comparison

Copy your main sound to B. Add lo-fi in B, then compare A and B over the same phrase. Hiss does not need to be loud to add texture. Check the end of notes as well as the attack.

04 / Compare, save and recall

Factory presets and OPEN replace the selected bank. The other bank is retained; COPY intentionally overwrites its destination.

A/B without losing the starting sound

- 1. Select A and choose a factory preset.
- 2. Click COPY TO B, then select B.
- 3. Change B or load another preset into it.
- 4. Switch A/B while a steady phrase plays.

LEVEL MATCH attenuates the louder bank by up to 18 dB. Allow a few seconds to settle. It does not boost the quieter bank or guarantee equal perceived loudness.

Save your own .patina preset

- 1. Select the bank you want to keep.
- 2. Click SAVE and use a name ending in **.patina**, such as **Evening keys.patina**.
- 3. Choose a folder; the initial location is Documents / PATINA Presets.
- 4. To recall, choose a bank and click OPEN.

SAVE * means edits since this editor opened or the last load/save in this bank. Reopening starts a new reference; it does not track DAW saves. Loading resets effect history.

Saved in a .patina file	Saved in your DAW project	Not saved as sound history
One bank's sound controls, including Restore, Bypass and effect LEDs.	Both banks, bank selection and global Level Match, alongside the current parameters.	Echo/reverb buffers and current age progress. Preset files also exclude DAW tempo and Level Match.

05 / Recipes for musical parts

Load the named preset first. Keep Evolve off, Restore released and FX POWER orange. Values below override the preset; other values stay as loaded.

Dusty piano

Start: Worn piano. Play a sparse piano or electric-piano phrase.

Wear 40%, Instability 8%, Mix 55%.

Delay LED on: Sync off, Time 280 ms, Feedback 25%, Amount 20%.

Reverb LED on: Size 40%, Amount 18%.

Listen for: soft edges with a clear first strike. Reduce Mix if chords lose detail.

Floating pad

Start: Faded pads. Use a slowly changing sustained synth.

Wear 55%, Instability 12%, Mix 65%.

Delay LED on: Sync off, Time 650 ms, Feedback 45%, Amount 30%.

Reverb LED on: Size 80%, Amount 35%.

Listen for: a moving halo around the chord. Use fewer notes if the tails become crowded.

Worn drum room

Start: Aged drums. Use a simple drum loop with some space.

Wear 35%, Instability 0%, Mix 45%.

Delay LED on: Sync off, Time 90 ms, Feedback 12%, Amount 8%.

Reverb LED on: Size 25%, Amount 12%.

Listen for: body and short reflections without detuned drums. Lower Reverb Amount if hits blur.

06 / Recipes for atmosphere

These are suggested starting settings, not measured guarantees. Use your source and ears to set the final Mix and Output.

Faded digital memory

Start: Sun-bleached reel. Try a gentle synth melody or a sampled chord.

Wear 35%, Instability 10%, Mix 50%.

LO-FI LED on: Crush Mix 25%, Bit Depth 10, Rate Reduction 3x, Hiss 8%.

Keep the preset's ambience; reduce Delay Amount if it distracts.

Listen for: a little digital grain between notes. Raise Bit Depth if the decay breaks up too much.

Distant landscape

Start: Frozen postcard. Feed it rain, a room recording, wind or distant activity on an audio track.

Wear 45%, Instability 4%, Mix 60%.

Delay LED on: Sync on, Division 1/1, Feedback 35%, Amount 18%.

Reverb LED on: Size 85%, Amount 30%.

Listen for: depth without losing the location. Lower Wear if important details disappear.

A disappearing ending

Start: Last light. Use the closing phrase of a song or a held chord.

Wear 85%, Age Time 30 s, Instability 18%, Mix 65%.

Evolve ON; Repeatable ON for consistent playback starts.

Click Restore, then RESUME FX at the start of the passage. Keep audio playing.

Listen for: the tone gradually becoming older. PATINA ages the sound; use a DAW volume fade for a true fade to silence.

07 / Choose a factory starting point

Twenty effect presets, organised here by listening purpose. Preset names describe treatments; they do not contain samples or instruments.

Gentle colour / instruments	Movement / texture	Space / evolving passages
Subtle tape - light colour.	Unstable cassette - obvious drift.	Faded pads - softened sustained texture.
Gentle warmth - softening with stable pitch.	Rain on cassette - wobble, digital wear and dotted echoes.	Distant room - heavily faded tone.
Worn piano - darker keys.	Cracked radio - dark, crushed voice/sample treatment.	Temple after dusk - long dotted echoes.
Paper lantern - soft keys and gentle ambience.	Dusty projector - strong movement, grain and hiss.	Ghost waltz - triplet repeats.
Velvet room - restrained wear and compact reverb.	Aged drums - stronger colour, steady pitch.	Half remembered - dark half-note trails.
Sun-bleached reel - drift with mild digital wear.	Rusted drum room - short slap and a tight room.	Frozen postcard - whole-note ambience.
		Slow decay - 60-second evolution.
		Last light - 20-second evolution.

Most factory presets apply their treatment immediately with Evolve off. Slow decay and Last light deliberately change over time. For fair comparisons, use the same passage and let Level Match settle.

08 / If something does not sound right

Start with the incoming track, then check power, Restore, Mix and the individual effect amount.

What you notice	What to check
No sound at all	Confirm the source track produces audio with PATINA bypassed. PATINA is an audio effect, so it needs an instrument or recording feeding it.
Sound is clean / wear stays at 0%	Turn FX POWER on. If RESUME FX is shown, click it. Raise Wear and Mix. With Evolve on, allow time for age to grow.
An orange LED makes no difference	An enabled effect still needs Amount above zero. For lo-fi, raise Crush Mix or Hiss. Main Mix and Restore also govern the result.
Delay Time will not move	TEMPO SYNC disables the millisecond control. Change the note division, or turn Sync off. FALLBACK means the plugin is using 120 BPM.
Too much wobble, grit or blur	Lower Instability for steadier pitch. Raise Bit Depth or reduce Rate Reduction for smoother lo-fi. Lower Feedback and ambience Amounts for clearer notes.
Values change after loading a preset	DAW automation can override recalled settings. Pause the relevant automation while comparing fixed sounds. Save the selected bank before replacing it.
Tail disappears / the sound restarts	Repeatable resets histories on playback starts or detected seeks. Loading or copying presets also resets the affected bank. Turn Repeatable off for continuous passes.
Update fails or AU is missing	Close the DAW and run Update-Patina.command for an existing project, or Build-and-Install.command for a first build. For AU registration, use Refresh-AU.command. Share Build-log.txt or AU-Check-log.txt if it fails.

Guide checked against the PATINA 0.5.2 source and included README. This guide adds no plugin features. The supplied project builds AU and VST3 on your Mac; the latest native test results still need confirmation there.